and courts from Istanbul to Bengal all emulated Persian styles and often adopted Farsi (the Persian language) as administrative tongues[7]. This was similar to the manner in which the French language and the French court's customs dominated medieval Europe all the way to the courts of the Russian Czars, despite the fact that many of those kingdoms were rivals of France.

The Mughals not only adopted Persian culture and customs, including poetry and art, but also brought large numbers of Persians into the Empire as administrators, something a number of Arab Caliphs had done long before. This meant that by the time of Shah Jahan ("Shah" itself being a Farsi term), the Mughal court could no longer be considered Mongol-Turkic but instead fundamentally Persian in character, a cultural extension of the Persian heartland into Northern India[8]. That said, this did not, of course, trickle down into the common folk, who remained largely Hindu and spoke Sanskrit-derived languages.

Together, Persian and Hindu influences combined to help bring about the architectural design of the Taj Mahal, but the Persians may have also influenced the purpose of the Taj's very existence. Tombs have long played a central place in the world of Persian architecture, religion and social status, and even though the Mughal Shahs were Sunni Muslims, they and their empire were deeply influenced by religious currents emerging out of the Shi'a Persia; in fact, Mumtaz Mahal appears to have been a Shiite herself. At its heart, the Sunni-Shi'a divide was about how to choose leaders ("Caliphs"). The Sunnis believed that Caliphs did not have to possess any particular spiritual knowledge, and that instead they were to maintain order and protect Islamic learning and should be chosen by community consensus. The Shi'a, on the other hand, argued that the descendants of the Prophet Mohammed - particularly of his daughter Fatima and his cousin Ali - were blessed by Allah with spiritual insights and the power to govern with proper justice and piety. Because of this, the Shi'a have always venerated the Prophet's descendants and, importantly for the history of the Taj, have built shrines over the places of their burials. This means that, unlike the Sunni, the Shi'a religious landscape is dotted with shrines dedicated to various saintly figures[9].

As the stronghold of the Shi'a since the Safavid Dynasty (1501-1736), Iran/Persia fused this fascination with mausoleums with their own indigenous interest in such buildings. Persians had long built spectacular tombs like the